

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost Sunday

Resisting with Joy ~ Compassion

24 May 2026



His Holiness the Dalai Lama & Archbishop Desmond Tutu, April 15, 2008, Photo by Tomas/Seeds of Compassion

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on LYONS and NETTLETON

The Olive Tree (Li Tai-Xiang, arr. Saunder Choi; adapted for organ by C. Bull)

Seguidilla from *Carmen* (Georges Bizet)

Meditation on Chant *Regina Caeli*

Regina Coeli, K. 276 (Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart)

Laudate Dominum (Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Pentecost Words of Gathering

Lisa Domke, Will Domke & Rev. Lehman

Come, from every corner of the earth,
from every time and place
from south and north
from east and west
gather
gather
gather here in this time
and in this place.

For the Spirit of God is being poured out upon us
even now
upon the young and the old
upon our children
upon our siblings
of every color and nation
sexual orientation and gender identity
Upon each one of us gathered here!

We come from different places to this sacred place
of communal caring and celebration.

In the times which we now share,
may we be open to the Creative Spirit of God,
the Spirit of kindness and compassion.

In this time of worship,
may we be enriched by the company of each other,
and be drawn closer to the heart of life.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Pentecost Hymn of Gathering** *O Spirit of Power*

LYONS

O Spirit of Power, who dwells in us all,
Inspire us each hour to follow your call.
Awaken our vision to all we can be,
And challenge our labor to set people free.

Though many your names, Love reigns over all;
With you we can claim our life giving call.
Cast out all our fear so with you we can soar,
Creating a world never dreamed of before.

O Spirit of Love, compassionate Friend,
Within and above, your strength knows no end.
Your rivers of healing revive thirsty land;
All goodness and nourishment flow from your hand.

O Spirit of Power, O Love beyond thought,
Our gifts with you flower; what wonders are wrought.
Creator, Redeemer and Comforting Guide,
Illumine our lives as with you we abide.

- lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton [1946-2024]

***Balloon Release**

Dr. Ianthe Marini & First Kids First & Youth

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Spirit of the Living God, in you all things are in motion.
Where change is needed in our thinking or beliefs,
in our practices or ways of relating to each other,
be our guide.

Give us courage to stay present to that which
makes us uncomfortable.
Give us patience when we are unsettled.
Give us strength when we face loss.
Give us the faith to welcome necessary change,
eagerly or tepidly, for the sake of your dream for us.
[adpt/enfleshed]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"We are the Ones"
Laude

BERNICE JOHNSON REAGON
arr. SAUNDER CHOI

***The Lord's Prayer**

Lisa & Will Domke

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.
Amen and Amen!* [John Philip Newell]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

The spirit of imagination is a gift to all people.
The spirit of compassion is the gift of the earth.
The spirit of hope breathes
in those who are marginalized in this city
and throughout the world.

The spirit of freedom
was announced by those who went before us
and we proclaim it again today,
because the Spirit of Love is Christ's
gift to the church in every age.

This morning may we recognize:
*the love of the Spirit of God in Scripture,
the love of the Spirit of God among us,
the love of the Spirit of God within us.*

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Baptism of Angela Kim

Rev. Lehman

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Book of Acts, chapter 2

Lisa & Will Domke

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, on this day of Pentecost, we gather in celebration of your Spirit.
From deep within us, and from our daily lives,
and beyond this world and the next,
we are touched by this Spirit of Life.

By the power of the Spirit, our faith is born and our joy is sustained.
And like the first Christians so long ago,
we have many languages for faith, and many gifts of the Spirit.

Today, in this our sacred space, we speak from our hearts,
of what we know and love.

Today, in this our sacred space, we speak from our minds,
of our doubts, of our skepticism,
as we search for truths to live by.

Today, in this our sacred space, we speak from our faith,
be it fragile or firm; we speak how it shapes our lives.

Today, in this our sacred space, we speak from compassion,
as we reach out to each other,
and as together...we stretch for understanding.

*So, come now, Holy Spirit, come,
and breathe into our hearts this day.
Bless and inspire this sacred time
that we may live Spirit-filled lives
of love and compassion for all.*

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Come, Holy Spirit, Heavenly Dove"
Laude

JONATHAN DAVID

**Sermon
The Eucharist and Blessings**

Compassion ~ Something We Want to Become

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin
Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Today we celebrate the Spirit
that Jesus of Nazareth promised would come.
Jesus embodied this Spirit so wonderfully
that he became like a mirror to us,
showing us what we are capable of
when we allow this same Spirit
to work freely in our lives.

At this table, we pray
that people may see in us
the courage and the generosity
that characterized Jesus' life,
and we pledge ourselves
to be embodiments
of the Spirit Jesus bore
and of the dream Jesus dreamed.

*May people see in us
what we profess to have seen in Jesus –
the Spirit alive in our midst!*

With glad hearts
we gather in memory of Jesus.
We break and share bread
as a sign of our awareness
of the Spirit always with us
in all we do
and as a sign of our commitment
to love generously and wholeheartedly.

We drink this fruit of the vine
in joyful recognition
of a Spirit poured out
into our world and into our lives
and in gratitude
for the gifts we each have
and are called to share.

*May the Spirit within us
be a source of healing and hope.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come

forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Lisa Domke

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Let The People Praise Thee"
Cathedral Choir

WILLIAM MATHIAS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Lisa Domke

*Spirit of Life, Hope, and Joy,
we sense your presence in this place.
Awaken us again to the mysteries that humble us,
the realities that orient us,
the friendships that sustain us,
that we may give ourselves in honesty and openness
to the expanding life before us!*

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

God has gathered us together for a purpose –
a living, moving, breathing purpose
that calls us to live differently,
to live passionately,
and to live courageously.

*With the Spirit as our guide, let us go from here
open to the wild ways of God,
however and in whomever She may be revealed.*

Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

"Compassion Meditation" Cathedral Choir

DAVID HARRIS

*"May you avoid suffering, May you be happy, May you be healthy, May you have peace and joy."
~His Holiness The Dalai Lama*

*Hymn for the Journey

Come, O Fount Of Every Blessing

NETTLETON

Come, O Fount of every blessing, tune my heart to sing your grace;
Streams of mercy, never ceasing, call for songs of endless praise.
Teach me some melodious sonnet, sung by flaming tongues above.
Praise the mount; I'm fixed upon it, mount of God's unfailing love.

Here I pause in my sojourning, giving thanks for having come,
Come to trust, at every turning, God will guide me safely home.
Jesus sought me when a stranger, wandering from the fold of God,
Came to rescue me from danger, blessed body, precious blood.

O to grace how great a debtor daily I am drawn anew!
Let that grace now, like a fetter, bind my wandering heart to you.
Prone to wander, I can feel it, wander from the love I've known:
Here's my heart, O take and seal it, seal it for your very own.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Komm, Heiliger Geist, Herre Gott (Georg Philipp Telemann)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"Pentecost and compassion have some interesting overlap. Compassion researcher Paul Gilbert defines compassion as "Sensitivity to suffering in self and other, and the desire to alleviate and prevent it." Compassion, therefore, is a motivator. It pushes us to hear one another and connect. When the folks were gathered for Pentecost, they were steeped in suffering. They didn't know what to do with the cards dealt them. By the end of the day, they were hearing each other in new ways. Guided by the spirit through compassion they found deep connection and purpose. The introit "We Are The Ones" reminds us that whatever is in front of us is ours to respond to. The text to Jonathan David's meditation that we premiered years ago reflects on the reasons why people suffer. The poet, Isaac Watts, includes the toys that distract us, our adherence to meaningless formalities and hierarchies, and the limits we set on love. He asks the spirit to move through us and alleviate our suffering. The music proceeds in a hymn-like fashion punctuated with some text painting to help bring us into contact with the meaning of the words. Mostly, it relies on beauty and flow to offer us a life line into compassion. Mathias' "Let The People Praise Thee," set to Psalm 67, is a grand celebration of human community. The soaring melody rides an organ wave that fills the air. He, interestingly, couples the soprano and first alto, and the tenor and second alto in separate duets that mean the alto part sings in near constant dissonance during the upbeat sections. The crunch brings a decisive, charged energy that reflects how our differences and conflicts are an essential part of community. In the middle of the piece, he slows into an Anglican style chant that asks for mercy and blessing for all people. We're all in this thing together. I wrote "Compassion Meditation" the last time we used "The Book Of Joy" for a sermon series. The words come from "The Book Of Joy," and have become a daily mantra for me. I love how the simplicity of the prayer offered by the Dalai Lama has brought slow, persistent change to my outlook on life. I created the music as a form of release and settling. Gilbert's research shows again and again that when we acknowledge our suffering and make room for others to be aware of theirs, we make space for release. Through that

release we find the true gift of compassion, just as the people of Pentecost did. We feel heard, and as if we can hear others. This leads to connection and recognition of presence in the world.”

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